



AMISH

THE PLAIN PEOPLE

ORIGINALLY PART OF THE PROTESTANT MENNONITE church, the Amish order originated in Switzerland in the 16th century. Persecuted cruelly in a Catholic age—even martyred in some countries—many of their people headed for the United States, whose founders promised freedom of religion. Today, there



GETTING AROUND

The Amish are not permitted to own motorized vehicles, so they drive horses and buggies instead of cars. This limits the distance they can travel easily from their stable, fairly insular, communities. If they do need to visit far-flung relatives, they are happy to make the journey by plane, train, or bus.



Home on the farm

Amish people live in small farming communities. Their pretty white homes are cozy and practical, with heat from wood or coal stoves, power from low-voltage generators, and light from gas lamps. There are no private telephones, but groups of neighbors often install a single, communal phone for emergencies.

ALL FOR ONE

When people need a new house or barn, their friends all join together to help them build it.



1 Making plans
Amish Elders plan a barn-building session for a newlywed couple. The construction itself is called a “raising”; the whole gathering is called a “frolic.”



2 Team effort
During the morning, neighborhood men assemble the frame of the traditional barn. Amish women contribute by preparing meals for the workers.



3 Final result
By the end of the work day the task has been completed. The design of Amish barns, with their steeply pitched roofs, has not changed for over a century.

The Amish believe that working with animals is part of God's plan for them to be close to nature.

LIVING ON THE LAND

The Amish work mainly in agriculture or related trades like blacksmithing and saddlery. Although their farm machinery is often modern in design, it is always horse powered. Some of the yield they produce is consumed within the community, but much of it is traded with outsiders (or *Englishers* as the Amish call them).

